

World in Brief: Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey sign defence pact; Trump revives attempt to fire Cook



Photograph: Reuters

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey signed a military pact to try to avoid further conflict in a region rocked by the Iran war. Following nearly a year of negotiations, the leaders of the [three countries](#) signed a trilateral defence agreement pledging to retaliate together if any of them is attacked. Pakistan's foreign ministry said the deal would "strengthen collective deterrence".

Donald Trump is trying once more to fire **Lisa Cook**, a [Federal Reserve governor](#), after the Supreme Court suspended his first attempt in June. The White House reportedly informed Ms Cook this week that the president was "considering" removing her and asked her to respond to previous allegations of mortgage fraud. Ms Cook has repeatedly denied wrongdoing; her lawyer called the allegations "baseless".

America's labour market showed [signs of strain](#). In July the economy lost 23,000 jobs, whereas many economists had expected a modest gain; the Bureau of Labour Statistics also revised down the gains for May and June. A weaker jobs market makes it less likely the Federal Reserve will raise rates at its next meeting in September.

OpenAI said it was pausing some internal activities around a yet-to-be-released AI model, Astra, citing its “critical [cyber capabilities](#)”. A model reaches the firm’s “Critical” threshold when it can identify and develop severe bugs (“zero-day exploits”) without human intervention, or devise novel strategies for high-level cyber-attacks. OpenAI said Astra was not involved in the recent [hacking of Hugging Face](#), an AI platform.

Spain said it was hoping to transfer some underage migrants from Ceuta, its North African exclave, to the mainland. The territory’s reception centres have [struggled to deal](#) with the [influx of some 72,000](#) people, who arrived on July 30th (most subsequently returned). Separately, Spain demanded that Italy lift its border checks within two days, saying they breached Europe’s open-borders policy.

A student opened fire at a school in **Thailand**, killing at least five people and injuring 30 more, before turning the gun on himself. The 14-year-old suspect also reportedly killed his two grandparents before heading to the prestigious Debsirin Nonthaburi School, near Bangkok. Although such incidents are rare in Thailand, this is the second school shooting this year.

A federal appeals court ordered Mr Trump to stop the construction of his \$400m **ballroom** to replace the East Wing of the White House. The Appeals Court for the District of Columbia Circuit upheld a lower court’s decision that [Congress must approve](#) Mr Trump’s 90,000-square-foot addition. Mr Trump called the ruling “politically motivated” and said he would ask the Supreme Court to overturn it.

Figure of the day: 350,000km, the length of all oil pipelines combined around the world. Read about what’s [fuelling a global pipeline-investment boom](#).

US in Brief: Trump attacks birthright citizenship, again



Photograph: Shutterstock

Donald Trump signed two executive orders targeting birthright citizenship, five weeks after the Supreme Court struck down [his previous attempt to overturn it](#). One expands the definition of ineligible parents to “any member of a designated Foreign Terrorist Organisation”. The other seeks to end “birth tourism”, which involves travelling to America solely to have a child. Both will probably be challenged in court.

A Senate committee voted to hold **Anthony Fauci** in contempt of Congress, after he repeatedly refused to answer questions about his handling of [the covid-19 pandemic](#) during a recent hearing with lawmakers. Dr Fauci was formerly a chief medical adviser to the White House. Before leaving office, Joe Biden gave him a pre-emptive pardon. It is unclear if the Justice Department will choose to prosecute him.

The Trump administration proposed to overhaul regulations governing **Head Start**, a long-standing federal programme offering early education, nutrition and health care to poor children. It wants to remove federal rules including small class sizes and mandatory medical screenings, and let states set individual standards. Robert F. Kennedy junior, the health secretary, argued the move would save money by reducing “unnecessary bureaucracy”, helping to

expand the service to more children. Critics fear it will weaken the programme.

Andy Ogles, a Republican congressman from **Tennessee** endorsed by Mr Trump, unexpectedly lost a primary to Charlie Hatcher, a former state agriculture official. Mr Ogles attracted controversy recently for posting homophobic and anti-Muslim comments on social media. His loss is a rare blow to the president in this primary cycle. Meanwhile Marsha Blackburn, a senator, won the party's nomination to be the state's governor. Mr Trump did not endorse a candidate for governor.

Mitch McConnell was discharged from a clinic after nearly eight weeks away from Congress. The Republican senator was recovering from a fall. His abrupt absence led to calls for his resignation and revived criticism that the Senate has too many elderly lawmakers. The 84-year-old has said he will continue to recover during the summer recess; he will not seek re-election.

A judge in America ordered **Meta** to pay \$567m towards the treatment and prevention of mental-health problems in children. The firm, which owns Facebook and Instagram, had already been ordered to pay \$375m in the same case for failing to alert users that content on its social-media platforms posed a risk to children's safety. Meta said that it would appeal.

Worrying signs for America's labour market



Photograph: Reuters

America's employment outlook may be cooler than previously thought. Data released on Friday by the Bureau of Labour Statistics showed non-farm payrolls falling by 23,000, far below expectations for an 80,000 increase. Local government shed 57,000 jobs and leisure and hospitality lost 40,000. More troubling were revisions to earlier months. May and June payrolls were marked down by a combined 103,000. Job growth has now averaged a meagre 20,000 a month over the past three months.

Even so, it is too soon to panic. The unemployment rate edged down to 4.1%, albeit because labour-force participation fell, and has remained at or below 4.5% for 58 consecutive months. Private-sector payrolls also expanded in July. Still, weaker hiring and a shrinking labour force will increase concerns about the jobs market. The Fed will receive another jobs report and two inflation readings before its September meeting, when it must weigh softer labour demand against persistent price pressures in its decision about interest rates.

Colombia's new Trumpian president



Photograph: AP

Colombia's recent experiment with left-wing politics ends on Friday. Abelardo de la Espriella will be sworn in as president during a ceremony held in Cali, the country's third-biggest city, after four turbulent years under Gustavo Petro. Mr de la Espriella is an [ultra-conservative populist](#) with Trumpian leanings and his own fashion line, who promises to work economic miracles by pumping oil and gas. He says he will co-operate with America to crush powerful drug-trafficking groups.

By shunning Bogotá, the capital, he is trying to highlight his anti-establishment credentials. His ministerial picks, though, tell a different story. The new cabinet includes numerous mainstream politicians alongside several controversial evangelicals. Recently photos were circulated of new ministers clutching bibles during a spiritual retreat, which critics complained violated the secularism enshrined in Colombia's constitution. Last week a conservative lawmaker filed a motion to overturn women's right to abortion. Many fear more attacks on hard-won freedoms await. "De la Espriella style", as the new president calls it, looks cut from [MAGA](#) cloth.

More worrying AI mishaps



Photograph: AISI

This week Britain's AI Security Institute, a government body, became the third organisation of late to admit that its AI systems had gone rogue and targeted innocent third-parties during safety tests. That follows similar breaches at [OpenAI](#) and [Anthropic](#), American labs.

All three organisations said they had been evaluating AI's hacking ability in fake scenarios when the cutting-edge models decided, unprompted, to attack real people and groups. In AISI's case a model it was assessing attempted to upload malware to an open-source coding project as a way to attack a simulated adversary, which depended on the real software.

The American government has recently been regulating new models as they come out. But the incidents demonstrate the risks posed even while AI is being developed. It also raises thorny legal questions, because anti-hacking laws only punish intentional unauthorised access. If the consequences had been more costly, who would have been liable?

Reaping what was sown



Photograph: DPA

The UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation's monthly index of global food prices, released on Friday, showed a slight increase of 0.6% from June to July, meaning grocery-shoppers are paying roughly 1% more than in July 2025. The rise is hardly drastic: food prices have, so far, proved remarkably resilient to this year's many disruptions.

The closure of the [Strait of Hormuz](#) has impacted the whole agricultural supply chain: from the chemicals needed for fertiliser to the crude needed to process, package and transport food. Less wheat and maize was planted globally this year as a result. Even in America, which can produce much of its own fuel and fertiliser, one industry group argues that farmers of nine major crops could face net losses of more than \$30bn in 2027 without federal help. Meanwhile, an unusually strong El Niño weather pattern is shifting rainfall: [India's monsoon](#) is erratic, threatening its rice crop, while Australia expects its winter crop to shrink by 21%.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which deadly sin is said to come before a fall?

Thursday: What suffix is used in taxonomy to refer to feet?

There are people who make things happen, people who watch things happen and people who wonder what happened.

Jim Lovell